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Friedrich Nietzsche, *Thus Spoke Zarathustra*, trans. Thomas Common (New York: Macmillan, 1909), Book III, §49, Project Gutenberg, <https://www.gutenberg.org/files/52881/52881-h/52881-h.htm>.

Book 3 – 49 – The Bedwarfing Virtue

[3_49:1] When Zarathustra was again on the continent, he did not go straightway to his mountains and his cave, but made many wanderings and questionings, and ascertained this and that; so that he said of himself jestingly: “Lo, a river that floweth back unto its source in many windings!”

[3_49:2] For he wanted to learn what had taken place AMONG MEN during the interval: whether they had become greater or smaller. And once, when he saw a row of new houses, he marvelled, and said: “What do these houses mean? Verily, no great soul put them up as its simile!

[3_49:3] Did perhaps a silly child take them out of its toy-box? Would that another child put them again into the box!

[3_49:4] And these rooms and chambers—can MEN go out and in there? They seem to be made for silk dolls; or for dainty-eaters, who perhaps let others eat with them.”

[3_49:5] And Zarathustra stood still and meditated. At last he said sorrowfully: “There hath EVERYTHING become smaller!

[3_49:6] Everywhere do I see lower doorways: he who is of MY type can still go therethrough, but—he must stoop!

[3_49:7] Oh, when shall I arrive again at my home, where I shall no longer have to stoop—shall no longer have to stoop BEFORE THE SMALL ONES!”—And Zarathustra sighed, and gazed into the distance.—

[3_49:8] The same day, however, he gave his discourse on the bedwarfing virtue.

2.

[3_49:9] I pass through this people and keep mine eyes open: they do not forgive me for not envying their virtues.

[3_49:10] They bite at me, because I say unto them that for small people, small virtues are necessary—and because it is hard for me to understand that small people are NECESSARY!

[3_49:11] Here am I still like a cock in a strange farm-yard, at which even the hens peck: but on that account I am not unfriendly to the hens.

[3_49:12] I am courteous towards them, as towards all small annoyances; to be prickly towards what is small, seemeth to me wisdom for hedgehogs.

[3_49:13] They all speak of me when they sit around their fire in the evening—they speak of me, but no one thinketh—of me!

[3_49:14] This is the new stillness which I have experienced: their noise around me spreadeth a mantle over my thoughts.

[3_49:15] They shout to one another: “What is this gloomy cloud about to do to us? Let us see that it doth not bring a plague upon us!”

[3_49:16] And recently did a woman seize upon her child that was coming unto me: “Take the children away,” cried she, “such eyes scorch children’s souls.”

[3_49:17] They cough when I speak: they think coughing an objection to strong winds—they divine nothing of the boisterousness of my happiness!

[3_49:18] “We have not yet time for Zarathustra”—so they object; but what matter about a time that “hath no time” for Zarathustra?

[3_49:19] And if they should altogether praise me, how could I go to sleep on THEIR praise?

[3_49:20] A girdle of spines is their praise unto me: it scratcheth me even when I take it off.

[3_49:21] And this also did I learn among them: the praiser doeth as if he gave back; in truth, however, he wanteth more to be given him!

[3_49:22] Ask my foot if their lauding and luring strains please it! Verily, to such measure and ticktack, it liketh neither to dance nor to stand still.

[3_49:23] To small virtues would they fain lure and laud me; to the ticktack of small happiness would they fain persuade my foot.

[3_49:24] I pass through this people and keep mine eyes open; they have become SMALLER, and ever become smaller:—THE REASON THEREOF IS THEIR DOCTRINE OF HAPPINESS AND VIRTUE.

[3_49:25] For they are moderate also in virtue,—because they want comfort. With comfort, however, moderate virtue only is compatible.

[3_49:26] To be sure, they also learn in their way to stride on and stride forward: that, I call their HOBBLING.—Thereby they become a hindrance to all who are in haste.

[3_49:27] And many of them go forward, and look backwards thereby, with stiffened necks: those do I like to run up against.

[3_49:28] Foot and eye shall not lie, nor give the lie to each other. But there is much lying among small people.

[3_49:29] Some of them WILL, but most of them are WILLED. Some of them are genuine, but most of them are bad actors.

[3_49:30] There are actors without knowing it amongst them, and actors without intending it—, the genuine ones are always rare, especially the genuine actors.

[3_49:31] Of man there is little here: therefore do their women masculinise themselves. For only he who is man enough, will—SAVE THE WOMAN in woman.

[3_49:32] And this hypocrisy found I worst amongst them, that even those who command feign the virtues of those who serve.

[3_49:33] “I serve, thou servest, we serve”—so chanteth here even the hypocrisy of the rulers—and alas! if the first lord be ONLY the first servant!

[3_49:34] Ah, even upon their hypocrisy did mine eyes’ curiosity alight; and well did I divine all their fly-happiness, and their buzzing around sunny window-panes.

[3_49:35] So much kindness, so much weakness do I see. So much justice and pity, so much weakness.

[3_49:36] Round, fair, and considerate are they to one another, as grains of sand are round, fair, and considerate to grains of sand.

[3_49:37] Modestly to embrace a small happiness—that do they call “submission”! and at the same time they peer modestly after a new small happiness.

[3_49:38] In their hearts they want simply one thing most of all: that no one hurt them. Thus do they anticipate every one’s wishes and do well unto every one.

[3_49:39] That, however, is COWARDICE, though it be called “virtue.”—

[3_49:40] And when they chance to speak harshly, those small people, then do / hear therein only their hoarseness—every draught of air maketh them hoarse.

[3_49:41] Shrewd indeed are they, their virtues have shrewd fingers. But they lack fists: their fingers do not know how to creep behind fists.

[3_49:42] Virtue for them is what maketh modest and tame: therewith have they made the wolf a dog, and man himself man's best domestic animal.

[3_49:43] **"We set our chair in the MIDST"**—so saith their smirking unto me—**"and as far from dying gladiators as from satisfied swine."**

[3_49:44] That, however, is—MEDIOCRITY, though it be called moderation.—

3.

[3_49:45] I pass through this people and let fall many words: but they know neither how to take nor how to retain them.

[3_49:46] They wonder why I came not to revile venery and vice; and verily, I came not to warn against pickpockets either!

[3_49:47] They wonder why I am not ready to abet and whet their wisdom: as if they had not yet enough of wiseacres, whose voices grate on mine ear like slate-pencils!

[3_49:48] And when I call out: "Curse all the cowardly devils in you, that would fain whimper and fold the hands and adore"—then do they shout: **"Zarathustra is godless."**

[3_49:49] And especially do their teachers of submission shout this;—but precisely in their ears do I love to cry: "Yea! I AM Zarathustra, the godless!"

[3_49:50] Those teachers of submission! Wherever there is aught puny, or sickly, or scabby, there do they creep like lice; and only my disgust preventeth me from cracking them.

[3_49:51] Well! This is my sermon for THEIR ears: I am Zarathustra the godless, who saith: "Who is more godless than I, that I may enjoy his teaching?"

[3_49:52] I am Zarathustra the godless: where do I find mine equal? And all those are mine equals who give unto themselves their Will, and divest themselves of all submission.

[3_49:53] I am Zarathustra the godless! I cook every chance in MY pot. And only when it hath been quite cooked do I welcome it as MY food.

[3_49:54] And verily, many a chance came imperiously unto me: but still more imperiously did my WILL speak unto it,—then did it lie imploringly upon its knees—

[3_49:55] —Imploring that it might find home and heart with me, and saying flatteringly:
“See, O Zarathustra, how friend only cometh unto friend!” —

[3_49:56] But why talk I, when no one hath MINE ears! And so will I shout it out unto all the winds:

[3_49:57] Ye ever become smaller, ye small people! Ye crumble away, ye comfortable ones! Ye will yet perish—

[3_49:58] —By your many small virtues, by your many small omissions, and by your many small submissions!

[3_49:59] Too tender, too yielding: so is your soil! But for a tree to become GREAT, it seeketh to twine hard roots around hard rocks!

[3_49:60] Also what ye omit weaveth at the web of all the human future; even your naught is a cobweb, and a spider that liveth on the blood of the future.

[3_49:61] And when ye take, then is it like stealing, ye small virtuous ones; but even among knaves HONOUR saith that “one shall only steal when one cannot rob.”

[3_49:62] “It giveth itself”—that is also a doctrine of submission. But I say unto you, ye comfortable ones, that IT TAKETH TO ITSELF, and will ever take more and more from you!

[3_49:63] Ah, that ye would renounce all HALF-willing, and would decide for idleness as ye decide for action!

[3_49:64] Ah, that ye understood my word: “Do ever what ye will—but first be such as CAN WILL.

[3_49:65] Love ever your neighbour as yourselves—but first be such as LOVE THEMSELVES—

[3_49:66] —Such as love with great love, such as love with great contempt!” Thus speaketh Zarathustra the godless.—

[3_49:67] But why talk I, when no one hath MINE ears! It is still an hour too early for me here.

[3_49:68] Mine own forerunner am I among this people, mine own cockcrow in dark lanes.

[3_49:69] But THEIR hour cometh! And there cometh also mine! Hourly do they become smaller, poorer, unfruitfuller,—poor herbs! poor earth!

[3_49:70] And SOON shall they stand before me like dry grass and prairie, and verily, weary of themselves—and panting for FIRE, more than for water!

[3_49:71] O blessed hour of the lightning! O mystery before noontide!—Running fires will I one day make of them, and heralds with flaming tongues:—

[3_49:72] —Herald shall they one day with flaming tongues: It cometh, it is nigh, THE GREAT NOONTIDE!

[3_49:73] Thus spake Zarathustra.

Begin Commentary

[3_49:1] When Zarathustra was again on the continent, he did not go straightway to his mountains and his cave, but made many wanderings and questionings, and ascertained this and that; so that he said of himself jestingly: "Lo, a river that floweth back unto its source in many windings!"¹

He came back to dry land, wandered around, and questioned people. He is trying to understand this and that. Then joked to himself that he is like a river that flowed back to his source. That is cute symbolism because rivers pour out into the ocean. He is working backwards. Except that there is no true source, only the closed circuit of an impossible river.

¹LOU ANDREAS-SALOMÉ: gelten: siehe einen Fluss, der in vielen Windungen zurück zur Quelle fließt!« (Also sprach Zarathustra III 23.) Es ist kein Zufall, dass Nietzsche in seiner letzten Schaffensperiode zu seiner mystischen Lehre von einer ewigen Wiederkunft gelangte: das Bild des Kreises,—eines ewigen Wechsels in einer ewigen Wiederholung,—steht wie ein wundersames Symbol und Geheimzeichen über der Eingangspforte zu seinen Werken see a river flowing in many meanders back to its source!" (Thus Spoke Zarathustra III 23). It is no coincidence that in his final creative period Nietzsche arrived at his mystical doctrine of eternal recurrence: the image of the circle—of an eternal cycle in an eternal repetition—stands like a wondrous symbol and secret sign above the entrance to his works.

SPEC: Possible connection to the Greek legend of Oceanus. The Greek God who controlled a world-spanning river, which flowed back on itself. Beyond the river lay the entrance to the underworld and the Blessed Isles. Zarathustra has just come back from the Isles, where some of his followers were. Additionally, Odysseus in the Odyssey Book 11 had to cross the world-spanning river to enter the underworld. Next line,

[3_49:2] For he wanted to learn what had taken place AMONG MEN during the interval: whether they had become greater or smaller. And once, when he saw a row of new houses, he marvelled, and said: "What do these houses mean? Verily, no great soul put them up as its simile!"

There is a timeline question here. The reader might be wondering why Zarathustra thought much could have changed in a small amount of time that had passed. Highly speculative that perhaps the events of the 4th part took place during the interval yet were published later. Likely, he has high diagnostic confidence in his ability to see even the smallest change as proof of direction of movement.

Zarathustra could be saying with these last words "verily no great soul put them up as its simile". A criticism of bourgeois comfort. The new houses being built are not for greatness but for ease. Thus they reflect the soul of those who constructed them.

SPEC: Again another Greek connection is hinted at, the people who were said to live on the world-spanning river included a tribe of pygmies, i.e. very small people and this section is about people he calls small. He could be hammering the Greek connection since Socrates, Plato, and Aristotle argued that there was a connection between the soul, the home, and the city. Next line,

[3_49:3] Did perhaps a silly child take them out of its toy-box? Would that another child put them again into the box!

The disdain is just oozing out of him. Only a silly child could have built what those men consider new and worthy of them. It should not even require a full adult to put away, because that would require a grownup to bend over. Rather a child should help put away these childish things, that we adults presumably have pride in. Next line,

[3_49:4] And these rooms and chambers—can MEN go out and in there? They seem to be made for silk dolls; or for dainty-eaters, who perhaps let others eat with them."

TN: The sentence ends with *die auch wohl an sich naschen lassen*. Which has been translated as “who perhaps let others eat with them”.² Suggest instead also allow themselves to be eaten. Rendering the sentence. And these rooms and chambers—can MEN go out and in there? They seem to be made for silk dolls; or for dainty-eaters, who perhaps also allow themselves to be eaten.”

AC: Zarathustra is saying that these houses are so doll-like they are only fit for dolls, presenting an image of softness and eating snacks instead of substances so much that they are themselves tasty morsels. This is not a home fit for adults, it is fit for silk dolls and cupcakes. He is amazed that actual men would lower themselves to walk in and out of them. Next line,

[3_49:5] And Zarathustra stood still and meditated. At last he said sorrowfully: “There hath EVERYTHING become smaller!

There is an argument here that it wasn’t that the houses really were smaller than when Zarathustra left the mainland. It is what he accepts as big enough no longer includes them. He started his project to raise humanity up and after seeing the partial failure on the Blessed Isles and seeing that the new construction is worse than before the project is becoming a failure. Next line,

[3_49:6] Everywhere do I see lower doorways: he who is of MY type can still go therethrough, but—he must stoop!

Catering to casuals. The bar was lowered, everyone can pass in and now the giants have to stoop. You have to like the em-dash here. The dramatic pause. It is cute, right after the but. Almost as if he is coming to grips with what he is about to utter because he is looking for a way that it must be false to the last possible second. “-but he

²Auch: also, too. Wohl: well. An: expresses proximity or touch from the side. Sich: himself., Naschen: to eat sweet things. Lassen: to let, to allow <https://dictionary.cambridge.org/dictionary/German-english/auch>
<https://dictionary.cambridge.org/dictionary/German-english/wohl>
<https://dictionary.cambridge.org/dictionary/German-english/an>
<https://dictionary.cambridge.org/dictionary/German-english/sich>
<https://dictionary.cambridge.org/dictionary/German-english/naschen>
<https://dictionary.cambridge.org/dictionary/German-english/lassen>

must stoop!" is subtly different than but-he must stoop! The only real question is who is of his type. Since well he is pretty unique. Would suggest it is where he used that phrasing 2 sections earlier in Involuntary Bliss section 41 [3_47:17-18] "if he be master of a long will, silent even when he speaketh, and giving in such wise that he TAKETH in giving:— " and "a fellow-creator and fellow-enjoyer with Zarathustra". Next line,

[3_49:7] Oh, when shall I arrive again at my home, where I shall no longer have to stoop—shall no longer have to stoop BEFORE THE SMALL ONES!"—And Zarathustra sighed, and gazed into the distance.—

The lament after judgment, wishing to return to his home. The repetition is doing work here. It is not that he has to just stoop he has to stoop before the small ones. First lower yourself, then pretend what is still above ought to be above. That is the double offense. That gaze is into the distance presumably towards the direction of his home, a place that matches his size. Next line,

[3_49:8] The same day, however, he gave his discourse on the bedwarfing virtue.

The same day however. That is a strong however. Despite the multiple failures he is still going to try, not later, not some day, today. Bedwarfing, that which makes you smaller. Virtue as in a moral ideal, not as habit. He is giving a discourse on what cognitive process makes you grasp for smallness. It would be akin to a religious leader saying the virtue of gluttony. Since the next section 50 On the Olive Mount has him praise silence and hiding what you know whatever it was that made him throw in the towel is either in this section or between the sections. This is the last attempt in Book 3 to reach people. However, he has accepted the data to an extent, he is going to teach them what disease they have not what possibilities are available to them. A radical shift from the beginning of his mission when he only mentioned the Last Man Mediocrity hellscape after trying to get humanity to strive to the ubermensch. This teacher is tired of trying to get students an A, he is hoping to terrify them into not getting a failing grade. Next line,

[3_49:9] I pass through this people and keep mine eyes open: they do not forgive me for not envying their virtues.

Part 2 begins with this passage. We seem to be looking back on the result of his discourse on the bedwarfing virtue. We do not get to hear it directly, only snippets of the aftermath and during it. The effect is confusion on the reader which may be a mirror to the confusion of the townsfolk. A traveling preacher came in and did not say all the

things he is supposed to say. They are muddled and so are we. How appropriate that the beginning of this section started with 3rd person format while here we see the switch to 1st person format in the aftermath.

The line itself has points. He passes through, not staying with them. As he rejects all responsibility. As he passes he still observes and notes the cause of their anger. They have all these ideals and Zarathustra looks upon them and their virtues without wishing. Next line,

[3_49:10] They bite at me, because I say unto them that for small people, small virtues are necessary—and because it is hard for me to understand that small people are **NECESSARY!**

TN: The German "und weil es mir hart eingeht, dass kleine Leute nöthig sind!" hints that he accepts that small people are required but it is hard for him to accept that. Alternative translation They bite at me, because I say unto them that for small people, small virtues are necessary—and because it is hard for me to understand that small people are **NECESSARY!**³

AC: Zarathustra is in a rotten mood. They attack him because he says that if you don't matter you might as well have ideals that don't matter AND they bite at him because it is almost physically painful for Zarathustra to accept that people who don't matter to him are required. He presumably gave a discourse where he told the audience that their highest virtues were the right size for how pathetic they were, and it almost physically pains him that the nature of the world requires their existence.

RR: One wonders why the discourse did not go over well.

Next line,

[3_49:11] Here am I still like a cock in a strange farm-yard, at which even the hens peck: but on that account I am not unfriendly to the hens.

Earlier in the book he was clear that he does not believe in turning the other cheek. See section 19 The Bite of the Adder. He lists two relevant to this passage points. The first that failure to acknowledge harm from an enemy leads to your enemy and yourself being humiliated. It is better for both parties for a small revenge in his mind. The second when you deal with a person who is often alone with deep thoughts

³Hart: hard, harsh <https://dictionary.cambridge.org/dictionary/German-english/hart>

and hurt them in any way. They are not ever capable of forgiveness because they are not capable of forgetting. With that summary there are a few possibilities here:

1. He isn't following his own advice and he pays for it with his bitterness at the end of this section. He didn't return blow for blow so it turned inward and as the section indicates (combined with the next one) he was an anchorite and the stone went to the bottom. That is why he presented still waters the next section.

2. He considers the people there to be below a normal enemy, not even worth striking back. His argument for blow for blow is that it is humiliating to know you didn't even hurt the person you intended to hurt, so give them some dignity. These people are so small in his view they deserve nothing.

3. He is rationalizing his position, or maybe moralizing the situation. Zarathustra just came off a boat friendless and is following a river. Came to a town, and the one thing he kinda knows how to do didn't go over well. It isn't like he is in any position to force his will. So he inverts the moral hierarchy. He pretends that he chooses to not respond when the truth is he cannot. The author repeatedly argues will to power frustrated turns into resentment and the last lines are resentful. Zarathustra has no will to power anymore. That gaze towards the distance in the beginning of this section spells it out. He isn't even alone in his cave, he is in a strange farmyard where everyone is his boss.

Next line,

[3_49:12] I am courteous towards them, as towards all small annoyances; to be prickly towards what is small, seemeth to me wisdom for hedgehogs.

SPEC: Possible reference to the Hedgehog Dilemma, a parable by Schopenhauer. In it a group of hedgehogs want to snuggle close for warmth, yet every time they do, they sting one another by accident. The hedgehogs constantly adjust their distance from one another pushed between the two poles of warmth and dangers of quills.⁴

⁴Schopenhauer, Arthur, Adrian Del Caro, and Christopher Janaway. 2015. *The Cambridge Edition of the Works of Schopenhauer. [Parerga] Parerga and Paralipomena : Short Philosophical Essays Volume 2 ...* Cambridge Cambridge University Press.

Wikipedia Contributors. 2019. "Hedgehog." Wikipedia. Wikimedia Foundation. January 11, 2019. https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Hedgehog's_dilemma.

Could also be a callback to the Last Man see [1_0:112]. Zarathustra is claiming to be above the fray and maintains he won't return blow for blow with what is small. A charitable reading might be that advice is being offered to the reader to not bring out the intellectual weapons on those who cannot meet you at your level, else you will have to be small to make it a fair fight. Less charitable readings are probably more likely to be accurate here. Next line,

[3_49:13] They all speak of me when they sit around their fire in the evening—they speak of me, but no one thinketh—of me!

It is plausible that this is going on, he did enter this unnamed town and give an atypical discourse, it is also possible that author is showing the emotional state of Zarathustra here. That he is imagining a self-importance and concluding that since they are talking about him but are not correctly assessing how amazing he is they must not be thinking. Mechanical gossip. The image of sitting around their fire in the evening reflects private conversations that Zarathustra is not privileged to hear. It is difficult not to read into this passage times in life where we become convinced that everyone is whispering about us and convinced that everyone does not see who we really are. Also, could be a comment on the nature of having a reputation without a relationship. Next line,

[3_49:14] This is the new stillness which I have experienced: their noise around me spreadeth a mantle over my thoughts.

TN: Stille can be translated as silence, lernte can be translated as learned instead of experienced. Yet, there is also value in experienced as the translation here, since we will be discussing it in terms of learned in the next section. Mantel can be translated as coat⁵ changing the translation too: This is the new silence I have learned: the noise around me spreads a coat over my thoughts.

AC: Not the silence of lack of noise, a silence from noise. A concealing din that keeps the truth unheard. Possible readings of this passage include but are not limited to

1. He is claiming all the noise of gossip is covering his thoughts. An ironic stance. Usually the more eyes we have on a problem the closer we get to the truth of it. What they are doing is making it more obscure with more people. Since they are thinking with

⁵ Stille: quietness, silence, hush, stillness. Given the next section theme of silence being important for concealment silence is chosen here for this commentary. Mantel here is translated instead of presented, to help with sentence clarity. <https://dictionary.cambridge.org/dictionary/German-english/stille>
<https://dictionary.cambridge.org/dictionary/German-english/mante>

their mouths instead of looking and meditating, the way Zarathustra did for them earlier in this section.

2. He is developing the ability to learn how to be an eye of the hurricane. The calm stillness surrounded by noise and pointless energy.

3. The noise that creates a coat could be a muffle for his thoughts, making it so while they are still there, he can no longer hear them. Next line,

[3_49:15] They shout to one another: "What is this gloomy cloud about to do to us? Let us see that it doth not bring a plague upon us!"

TN: Suggest „was will uns diese düstere Wolke“ be translated as “what does this gloomy cloud want from us?”⁶

AC: We can read this from the townsfolk point of view. A wandering street preacher rolled into town, oozing contempt for them. This guy gave a discourse on the Bedwarfing Virtue. Presumably a long rant about how they were small and getting smaller. How all of their best ideals were worthless which was fine because he can hardly stomach their existence. These townsfolk ask themselves “what does this depressing fellow actually want from us?”, they don’t see it. Since Zarathustra gave a speech on the smallness not greatness so they come to the conclusion that they do not know what he wants but we have to make sure that none of us catch what it is that has made him so ill.

RR: This is not Zarathustra of the beginning who spoke of a glorious future, or the Zarathustra who spoke to his type his musings. This is resentful Zarathustra who has nothing left but telling everyone that they are utterly unlovable and should not even aspire higher. Next line,

[3_49:16] And recently did a woman seize upon her child that was coming unto me: "Take the children away," cried she, "such eyes scorch children's souls."

Thomas Common translates this with a more biblical tone. Echoing Jesus in the gospels telling people to allow the children to come unto him. Zarathustra describes an

⁶Will: from Wollen. To want. Uns: us

<https://dictionary.cambridge.org/dictionary/German-english/wollen>
<https://dictionary.cambridge.org/dictionary/German-english/uns>

inversion of that. With Jesus the people identified him as a holy man and did not want the children to bother someone important. Here they identify Zarathustra as a threat to the children, children who want to come to him. The almost reflex-level snatch of a concerned parent. This bible framing primes us for the god talk later in this section and continues the motif of the danger of spiritual contagion the people believe Zarathustra represents. The scorching eyes might be a reference to superstitions of the evil eye. The idea that a glance can harm. Next line,

[3_49:17] They cough when I speak: they think coughing an objection to strong winds—they divine nothing of the boisterousness of my happiness!

TN: Brausen⁷ is translated as boisterousness, suggest instead roar. Sentence would read instead “They cough when I speak: they think coughing an objection to strong winds—they divine nothing of the roar of my happiness!”

AC: The contagion motif continues. Coughing aligning with the plague motif. The townsfolk act as if an expression of disapproval could ward off what Zarathustra represents. They cough and make a small wind with their disapproval, Zarathustra roars with his happiness. Next line,

[3_49:18] “We have not yet time for Zarathustra”—so they object; but what matter about a time that “hath no time” for Zarathustra?

Another weak objection is raised to Zarathustra by the townsfolk. They do not have time for depth. Keeping the theme of scale in this section, their homes were already almost too small for him to fit in, now they claim their time is also insufficient. Zarathustra uses a Chiasmus here to affirm the truth of what they say. Yes, they do not have time for what he says. Fine, why should he care about such a small sum of time? Next line,

[3_49:19] And if they should altogether praise me, how could I go to sleep on THEIR praise?

⁷Brausen: to roar, to race, to rush

TN: the second praise here translated as praise can also be translated as fame.⁸ As it is two different words in the original German suggested translation becomes “And if they should altogether praise me, how could I go to sleep on THEIR fame?”

AC: And if, purely hypothetically, they would praise me, then how could I ever relax in their fame that they built for me? Not the ownership. Their fame. Most of us think of our fame, Zarathustra by his word choices is fully distancing himself from that potential fame. Next line,

[3_49:20] A girdle of spines is their praise unto me: it scratcheth me even when I take it off.

The imagery here of wearing a belt of thorns is worth considering. The idea of a belt of thorns around your waist is just painful. Even if you take it off the process is going to hurt and leave you marked. Usually when something hurts you take action to remove the pain, but a belt of thorns is going to hurt with any movement. Even when that movement is very goal-driven and clever. He isn't running around in mindless pain, instead he is slowly taking it off. Their praise would mean freezing him in place and still suffering, a slow removal would still hurt. It is like a medieval torture. A simile of social traps: accepting praise and forfeiting movement, reject and the suffering causes you pain and leaves you a marked one.

Zarathustra is arguing with himself, that even if the sermon had worked it would still not have worked out well for him. Next line,

[3_49:21] And this also did I learn among them: the praiser doeth as if he gave back; in truth, however, he wanteth more to be given him!

AC: He thinks that anyone saying how great someone is wants whatever it is that person does to do more of. Praise is self-motivated from praiser. It produces an obligation. You want more flattery? Go do that thing you did again. Praise pretends to be a gift but really is an obligation.

RR: Author might be hinting at sour grapes here. The evidence shown is that Zarathustra was not praised. Instead of accepting that he could not obtain what he desired he declares it of negative value. Next line,

⁸Rhume from Rhum. Fame, glory, renown.

<https://dictionary.cambridge.org/dictionary/german-english/ruhm>

[3_49:22] Ask my foot if their lauding and luring strains please it! Verily, to such measure and ticktack, it liketh neither to dance nor to stand still.

Asking a rhetorical question if his foot, his desire to dance, approves of the music they could make. The music being their praises and enticing. Then answering with a no. A vehement no that he would not even not dance to that tune. Next line,

[3_49:23] To small virtues would they fain lure and laud me; to the ticktack of small happiness would they fain persuade my foot.

The unplanned method of the townsfolk in dealing with the outliers and those too intense. Lure them and laud them. Offer prizes for compliance and praise as social control. With the result of those like Zarathustra moved into the endless dance monotony of ticktack tunes. A faint smell of an experienced teacher being able to coax a student into drills. You are such a fine young man, do you not want to have ice cream afterwards and everyone seeing how good of a job you did? Even success for him would be failure. Next line,

[3_49:24] I pass through this people and keep mine eyes open; they have become SMALLER, and ever become smaller:—THE REASON THEREOF IS THEIR DOCTRINE OF HAPPINESS AND VIRTUE.

This repetition of the beginning resembles a biblical literary structure called an Inclusio⁹. Earlier it was perception, now it is diagnosis.

In terms of what the sentence says it is implying that their doctrine of happiness and virtue, of shrinking down the large in their society, has turned inward. Zarathustra is passing through these people, he is not going to stick around. Targets like him either do the same or stay letting the bedwarfing virtue do the work. Conformity on conformity on conformity until everything is a pebble of the rock that it once was. Next line,

[3_49:25] For they are moderate also in virtue,—because they want comfort. With comfort, however, moderate virtue only is compatible.

He says they are small because of their happiness and virtue, their virtue is moderate. Why? Because they ultimately want comfort. And big virtue is incompatible with comfort. This is not the Aristotle golden mean, which is intended to lead to

⁹“Inclusio.” 2024. Wikipedia. February 6, 2024. <https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Inclusio>.

flourishing this is the moderate virtue that leads to smallness driven by the desire for comfort. Next line,

[3_49:26] To be sure, they also learn in their way to stride on and stride forward: that, I call their HOBBLING.—Thereby they become a hindrance to all who are in haste.

Here he is dismissing what they call their progress. Oh sure the townsfolk move, and move forward. Yet it is towards the direction of comfort. As they and their world become smaller and smaller they become a block for anyone who is aware of the passage of time. Next line,

[3_49:27] And many of them go forward, and look backwards thereby, with stiffened necks: those do I like to run up against.

As the townsfolk move towards greater comfort they give us a parody of human form. Head stiff back the way they came not at what lies ahead. The future is pursued but not faced. Zarathustra enjoys bumping into them. Before it was not clear to why he even bothered with his street preaching thing when he arrived. This is the first time we are seeing him express any kind of desire. It is not a noble like but it is some motivation. This would mean, if true, Zarathustra needs some friction with the social world to feel, if love and listening is not available he will take collision. Next line,

[3_49:28] Foot and eye shall not lie, nor give the lie to each other. But there is much lying among small people.

Foot and eye shall not lie. Both should report accurately. Feet should say forward when moving forward, eye shall see what is coming and say what is coming. Nor, shall both reports be true from their perspective but globally contradict. Zarathustra will not have it with two liars pledging fidelity with knives behind their backs nor two eyewitnesses who neither of which really saw the whole picture. Despite rejecting it he notes those townsfolk have much of it going on. Next line,

[3_49:29] Some of them WILL, but most of them are WILLED. Some of them are genuine, but most of them are bad actors.

We should keep in mind that Zarathustra here is engaged in conversation with us the reader. He is seeking to put an idea in our mind and the means of doing it is fair game to discuss. Here he is walking back his description of the townsfolk. Not all of

them are completely lost. Possibility, since his heaping attacks on them could be raising skepticism. They surely cannot be all beyond redemption we might say, hence he is conceding something small to make his condemnation look accurate. Also could be trying to recruit us the reader. Are we exerting our will or are we willed upon? Are we genuine or are we actors, and bad actors at that? Next line,

[3_49:30] There are actors without knowing it amongst them, and actors without intending it—, the genuine ones are always rare, especially the genuine actors.

TN: wider here is translated as without, it can also be translated as against.¹⁰ turning the sentence into “There are actors against their knowledge amongst them, and actors against their intention—, the genuine ones are always rare, especially the genuine actors.”

AC: First addressing the Thomas Common translation we have people acting without knowing it and people acting without their will being present. The actual genuine, people knowing what they are doing and intended what they do, are hard to find. Harder still are the actors amongst that minority.

Addressing the suggested revised translation we find a slight difference. The actors here in the town know better but act as if they do not also they move against their will. The genuine ones who live the knowledge they know and act with the will they have are very rare, the rarest amongst them can know the truth, know their will and act otherwise. True actors can make you believe they are who they play. Next line,

[3_49:31] Of man there is little here: therefore do their women masculinise themselves. For only he who is man enough, will—SAVE THE WOMAN in woman.

Zarathustra states the bedwarring virtue in gender terms. Claiming it takes those naturally strong and makes them weak such that they naturally weak have to become strong. Suggesting that at some future time it is possible the real strong will return the town to the proper order. Next line,

¹⁰Wider: against

[3_49:32] And this hypocrisy found I worst amongst them, that even those who command feign the virtues of those who serve.

According to Zarathustra the worst hypocrisy of the townsfolk is commanders pretending to the virtues of those who serve. The sophist just asking questions, the town mayor in a photo-op pretending to like a corn-dog, the manipulative preacher of virtues claiming to be but a humble servant of a higher power.

Keep in mind that the author hated Socrates. Socrates often pulled the humility maneuver. Claiming not to be a teacher while he taught, telling people he had no wisdom while presenting wisdom, arguing that he serves the good and virtue. All the while fully in control of the situation and the conversation. He ruled and claimed to serve. Until the last when he manipulated the Athenians under his shadow via the guilt in what they had done. Next line,

[3_49:33] “I serve, thou servest, we serve”—so chanteth here even the hypocrisy of the rulers—and alas! if the first lord be ONLY the first servant!

TN: chanteth can also be translated as prayed.¹¹ Changing the passage to “I serve, thou servest, we serve”—so pray here even the hypocrisy of the rulers—and alas! if the first lord be ONLY the first servant!

AC: A chant is often an affirmation. A prayer is a begging letter of supplication. The leadership begs that leadership be counted as submission. Diffusion of responsibility, diffusion of excellence, a diffusion of vision. Which will lead to the town being doomed as the top of hierarchy is at best only the highest rung of the ladder of submission. Next line,

[3_49:34] Ah, even upon their hypocrisy did mine eyes' curiosity alight; and well did I divine all their fly-happiness, and their buzzing around sunny window-panes.

Previously he identified the hypocrisy of the rulers, now he says he looked into it. He was curious and dug in. Then claims he saw their fly-like happiness. A fly is not particularly clever, whatever happens it has in life is very much on the simple physical

¹¹ Betet from Beten

level. He mentions the particular act flies are known for, buzzing around a windowpane. Could be a metaphor: a being trying to escape, heading towards the light, but stopped by a barrier that they can not see only crash into. Making lots of noise, performing a lot of movement, yet making no progress. Next line,

[3_49:35] So much kindness, so much weakness do I see. So much justice and pity, so much weakness.

SPEC: The double structure might be him trying to convince himself of what he is saying. He could have easily said “so much kindness, justice, and pity, so much weakness” instead he breaks it up into two clauses. An insistence rather than a description.

AC: According to Zarathustra here kindness, justice, and pity are what weak people do. They are kind hoping to avoid offense, they can not tolerate an unjust existence so they invent and enforce justice, they use pity as a means to lower those around them to their own size. Presumably a strong person is not kind they are demanding, they don’t whine about injustice they overpower, and they pity no one because that would be the worst insult. Next line,

[3_49:36] Round, fair, and considerate are they to one another, as grains of sand are round, fair, and considerate to grains of sand.

SPEC: Round suggests an erosion process, sharp uniqueness shaped slowly by mindless, without aim force of water.

AC: Zarathustra lists three aspects of the townsfolk. Round, fair, and considerate. He suggest a simile of sand. Grains of sand are round and small, thus they can interchangeable without uniqueness. A sand grain on the bottom of a pile can easily be made a sand grain on the top. Connecting to his carnival of roles earlier in this section. Next line,

[3_49:37] Modestly to embrace a small happiness—that do they call “submission”! and at the same time they peer modestly after a new small happiness.

The townsfolk embrace a small happiness, with modesty. Not with gusto, with the communication to one another that they are not worthy of even this small happiness. The small happiness that they take modestly they call submission. Maybe this can be seen as someone downplaying even their ability to serve. Yet the townsfolk do not even seem to truly want what they embraced. They look towards obtaining even a new small

happiness. The second part undercuts the message of the first. They embrace submission yet their eye's are on something else. Next line,

[3_49:38] In their hearts they want simply one thing most of all: that no one hurt them. Thus do they anticipate every one's wishes and do well unto every one.

We were told that they wanted some other small happiness in the previous line, this is what it is. It isn't to serve it is to avoid pain. Very much the ethics of a person who lacks all agency in their life. They might embrace their serving but really deep down what they want is no one to hurt them. They avoid all conflict, focus utterly on what other people wish and do kindness onto every one, lest one of them hurt one another. Almost as if it were fawning as a cultural strategy ¹². Next line,

[3_49:39] That, however, is COWARDICE, though it be called "virtue."—

The townsfolk have attempt to declare their small happiness into a virtue. Zarathustra refuses to play along with the switcheroo. He calls it being a coward. The fawning response is not aspirational, or at least not worthy of aspiration. Next line,

[3_49:40] And when they chance to speak harshly, those small people, then do / hear therein only their hoarseness—every draught of air maketh them hoarse.

Even when they, the Townsfolk, do push back Zarathustra downplays the effort to assert themselves. Pointing out that the Townsfolk voice rasp. He can hear the lack of strength. Every draught of air makes them hoarse could be a visual image. The mouth opens to speak and air is not drawn in, it just moves in the place. Next line,

[3_49:41] Shrewd indeed are they, their virtues have shrewd fingers. But they lack fists: their fingers do not know how to creep behind fists.

This passage mixes the properties of the Townsfolk with the properties of their virtues. They and their virtues have fingers, devices that can probe, prod, and be precise. Yet they lack fists, resolution, strength to back it up. The virtues and the people are unarmed, except with the fawning response discussed earlier. Next line,

¹²Guy-Evans, Olivia. 2021. "Fight, Flight, Freeze, or Fawn: How We Respond to Threats." Simply Psychology. October 6, 2021. <https://www.simplypsychology.org/fight-flight-freeze-fawn.html>.

[3_49:42] Virtue for them is what maketh modest and tame: therewith have they made the wolf a dog, and man himself man's best domestic animal.

A capstone argument. Virtue ought to be what leads us to excellence and flourishing, instead their virtue leads to domestication. Which is why they turned the wolf into a dog and turned themselves into the best pet for whomever is still left that is a man. Next line,

[3_49:43] “We set our chair in the MIDST”—so saith their smirking unto me—“and as far from dying gladiators as from satisfied swine.”

TN: Mitte here translated as midst can also be translated as middle ¹³. Making the passage “We set our chain in the middle”—so saith their smirking unto me—“and as far from dying gladiators as from satisfied swine.”

AC: The townsfolk seem to say to Zarathustra that they enjoy a calibrated perfection between those that still fight and strive vs. those that only consume and grow fat therefrom. It sounds reasonable but notice this is not a condemnation of rest, it is seen as a misuse of rest. Rest to more striving as opposed to rest as an ideal between no striving and consumption.

RR: one might wonder how Zarathustra can be so confident in this diagnosis from smirking alone. Next line,

[3_49:44] That, however, is—MEDIOCRITY, though it be called moderation.—

He rejects it and calls it mediocrity. He refuses to call it mere moderation. This virtue of mediocrity is not the Aristotelian mean of virtues being the middle of two vices it moderation pretending to be wisdom. The townsfolk, he claims, are committing moderation-as-alibi, a means to avoid striving and self-overcoming. Next line,

[3_49:45] I pass through this people and let fall many words: but they know neither how to take nor how to retain them.

¹³Mitte: Middle or center

Part 3. Line is similar to [3_49:9] and [3_49:24]. Creating an anaphora. In the previous two lines he said he was observing them, this time he is talking of his actions. He is moving through them while telling them many things that they do not know how to accept or even remember them. Next line,

[3_49:46] They wonder why I came not to revile venery and vice; and verily, I came not to warn against pickpockets either!

Based on the timeline. Namely, that we are seeing the post-sermon internal monologue of Zarathustra he seems to be saying that the townsfolk came to see his sermon act with expectations. That he came to yell at what they consider sin and too much pleasure. He did not, he came to give his discourse on the Bedwarfing Virtue. They think that they are the halfway point between gladiators and fighters, Zarathustra told them that they were mediocrity embodied and it is because of what they hold righteous, which in itself was the product of fear of strife. Zarathustra declares to himself that he is not here to do that and he did not even come to remind them of civic virtue. He is the herald of the Ubermensch not a preacher of prudence. Next line,

[3_49:47] They wonder why I am not ready to abet and whet their wisdom: as if they had not yet enough of wiseacres, whose voices grate on mine ear like slate-pencils!

TN: the last part of the passage can also be translated more literally ¹⁴ would change this to “They wonder why I am not ready to abet and what their wisdom: as if they had not yet enough of wiseacres, whose voices sound similar to pencils on slates!

¹⁴deren Stimme mir gleich Schieferstiften kritzelt!

Deren: There

Stimme: voice

gleich: same, similar

Schiefer-stiften: slate and pencil

Cambridge Dictionary. 2026. “Deren.” @CambridgeWords. January 28, 2026.
<https://dictionary.cambridge.org/dictionary/german-english/deren>.

Cambridge Dictionary. 2026. “Stimme.” @CambridgeWords. January 28, 2026.
<https://dictionary.cambridge.org/dictionary/german-english/stimme>.

Cambridge Dictionary. 2026. “Gleich.” @CambridgeWords. January 28, 2026.
<https://dictionary.cambridge.org/dictionary/german-english/gleich>.

Cambridge Dictionary. 2026. “Schiefer.” @CambridgeWords. January 28, 2026.
<https://dictionary.cambridge.org/dictionary/german-english/schiefer>.

2026. Wiktionary.org. 2026. <https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/Stift#German>.

AC: The townsfolk during the sermon he gave wondered why Zarathustra would not help them aid and sharpen their wisdom, as presumably other street preachers have done so in the past. Since Zarathustra says they have had enough of those clever people already. The slate and pencil imagery calls to mind a scratchy voice. One with no power left behind it, commanding attention via irritation. Next line,

[3_49:48] And when I call out: “Curse all the cowardly devils in you¹⁵, that would fain whimper and fold the hands and adore”—then do they shout: “Zarathustra is godless.”

We begin shifting tenses in this section moving from him recalling past events to now him talking about timeless universal judgments. In his mind if he says this quasi-Biblical verse the assemblies will respond that he is a godless one. It will happen and it has happened. There almost is a prophetic unavoidable nature to this cause and effect. If Zarathustra curses the cowardly devils, everyone in assembly will call him godless.

The three parts described are also worth noting. The whimper, the folding of the hands, and adoration. Speech, action, and feeling. A tripart of being a coward.

Lastly, the assembly does not try to argue what he said, or his right to say it, they attack what he is. Before when he spoke they tried to cough over him, when he said this they spoke out. Next line,

[3_49:49] And especially do their teachers of submission shout this;—but precisely in their ears do I love to cry: “Yea! I AM Zarathustra, the godless!”

Not just priests, it could be anyone who teaches the doctrine of submission. Those are the ones that shout this. Godless fits as a pejorative label significant to the group that this one is not safe. Rather than be taken back by the accusation Zarathustra owns it and loves to throw it at them proudly proclaiming who he is and what he is. Next line,

[3_49:50] Those teachers of submission! Wherever there is aught puny, or sickly, or scabby, there do they creep like lice; and only my disgust preventeth me from cracking them.

AC: According to Zarathustra: those that teach the doctrine of being submissive, you will find them wherever there are humans who are small, of ill-health, or been injured many times. These teachers will creep, not boldly approach, creep, to act as

¹⁵Might be an allusion to Matthew 25:41

parasites off the sick human animal not the healthy human animal. Zarathustra claims that only his disgust at how they behave keeps them from crushing those teachers of submission.

RR: One wonders if this was a story he was telling himself to justify the lack of power he has in this town. Claiming he could beat his vague enemies but chooses not too. Next line,

[3_49:51] Well! This is my sermon for THEIR ears: I am Zarathustra the godless, who saith: "Who is more godless than I, that I may enjoy his teaching?"

We can almost hear the exasperation in that "well". Zarathustra addresses the teachers of submission, who threw out atheist as a pejorative at him. He demands they find a person who is even more an atheist so he could learn from that person. It is possible Zarathustra is also implying here that he will not learn from an equal or someone he considers beneath him. Only someone who is greater or at least more free than himself. Next line,

[3_49:52] I am Zarathustra the godless: where do I find mine equal? And all those are mine equals who give unto themselves their Will, and divest themselves of all submission.

Zarathustra asks, perhaps rhetorically, for the world to produce his equal. His criteria of ranking the human race is following authentic will and throwing off all forms of submission. A ranking indicates a system of values, here we have him show us his. Next line,

[3_49:53] I am Zarathustra the godless! I cook every chance in MY pot. And only when it hath been quite cooked do I welcome it as MY food.

The abrupt change from him yelling at the teachers of submission to demanding the world produce a more godless one leads us to this sentence of contrast. Zarathustra consumes all the chances of life, but only after he cooks them. Good, bad, boring, exciting he takes them all. Finds meaning, uses the energy as a gift from the uncaring universe. This is not the submissive stance of accepting whatever life hands you, this is the agency driven, yes-saying, stance of the creating godless one.

This passage seems to restate [3_48:18] slightly differently. Where Zarathustra expresses an urge to convert problems into instruments for music.

Next line,

[3_49:54] And verily, many a chance came imperiously unto me: but still more imperiously did my WILL speak unto it,—then did it lie imploringly upon its knees—

Zarathustra personifies chance as an arrogant visitor. Coming to him like he is the boss of Zarathustra. Zarathustra's will responds with even more arrogance. Dominating chance to its knees. Zarathustra is suggesting that the contingency of our lives are the only thing that ought to kneel, not us. Or at least not men of his type. Next line,

[3_49:55] —Imploring that it might find home and heart with me, and saying flatteringly: "See, O Zarathustra, how friend only cometh unto friend!" —

Chance events wants home and heart with him, thus chance events says this almost witticism. Friend only comes onto friend. Chance events are trying to ingratiate themselves. In the previous line he says that chance is lying here. There is almost a moral right demanding thing going on. Zarathustra looks at chance events as fuel, a thing he uses. Here the avatar of chance events seems to be "saying" let me live in your home as your friend. Not consumed, not digested, as a companion. Next line,

[3_49:56] But why talk I, when no one hath MINE ears! And so will I shout it out unto all the winds:

The townsfolk rejected him, they have hearing but not the kind of hearing Zarathustra has. He then asks himself rhetorically why he is speaking at all. Rather than become despondent he announces he will shout it to all the winds. A slight prophetic cadence of Ezekiel 37:9 which might be for priming the user to accept a prophetic voice, as the next few passages are making proclamations about the future. Next line,

[3_49:57] Ye ever become smaller, ye small people! Ye crumble away, ye comfortable ones! Ye will yet perish—

Zarathustra announces that as small as they are the bedwarfing process will make them smaller still. Eventually they will fall apart, they will succumb. This triple addressing of ye really gives a biblical feel to his prophecy. The small shall become smaller, the comfort seeking shall crumble away, both shall perish. Next line,

[3_49:58] —By your many small virtues, by your many small omissions, and by your many small submissions!

Continues the triple structure. Virtues, omissions, and submissions, all small. What they strives for, what they did not do, and whom they bowed too. Those three, according to Zarathustra, will bring about their perishing. The omissions are worth noting. What will bring the end to the townsfolk is not only what they did do but what they did not do. The million little spoken and unspoken refusals that prevented growth from ever becoming an option. Next line,

[3_49:59] Too tender, too yielding: so is your soil! But for a tree to become GREAT, it seeketh to twine hard roots around hard rocks!

TN: suggest tender be translated as lenient¹⁶. Making the passage “Too lenient, too yielding: so is your soil! But for a tree to become GREAT, it seeketh to twine hard roots around hard rocks!”

AC: The townsfolk are likened as a tree, with their source of nutrition and position, their roots, digging into a certain soil. A soil that not only gives away but seems to want to show mercy to the root's growth. Yet for a tree to grow is must seek unyielding rocks to grasp and hold. There is a repeat of the metaphor with a different message in [1_8:7] with the youth on the hill. “The more he seeketh to rise into the height and light, the more vigorously do his roots struggle earthward, downward, into the dark and deep—into the evil”

The contrast here of roots twining around rocks vs. the passages before with chance and Zarathustra claiming to always seek to consume it. Greatness requires resistance that remains intact, similar to wrestling with a great thinker. The intellectual soil of the townsfolk is not such that it needs to be wrestled with, it is lenient on them. Next line,

[3_49:60] Also what ye omit weaveth at the web of all the human future; even your naught is a cobweb, and a spider that liveth on the blood of the future.

¹⁶Schonend from schonen: to spare, to go easy on

Also what the townspeople do not do weaves into the web of the future of the human race. Non-actions, non-words, non-states does not vanish but in itself has a form of substance that joins the future. Even what you refuse becomes a complex trap for a predator. A predator that will exploit the nothingness to drain the life out of the future. With the omissions the spider web is set, with the bedwarfing virtue humanity will continue to shrink to the size of flies. Small as we are the omissions cobweb will make even the lowly spider be threatening.

It is clever how he upgrades personal omissions to historical ones. The omissions, the nothings, are not neutral. They also build the future. The web to cobweb is change is a possible downgrade. There is almost noble about being part of a web like tapestry of the future, this web is not that. It is a cobweb. Thin and dusty and found in places of neglect. Next line,

[3_49:61] And when ye take, then is it like stealing, ye small virtuous ones; but even among knaves HONOUR saith that **"one shall only steal when one cannot rob."**

When the townsfolk take, when they obtain anything, when they assert themselves in any fashion, it is like stealing to them. As in to get what one is not entitled to have. Even a real criminal is avoids being so low. Look, at the inversion here: he is holding up those who are seen as bad as above those seen as good. Next line,

[3_49:62] **"It giveth itself"**—that is also a doctrine of submission. But I say unto you, ye comfortable ones, that IT TAKETH TO ITSELF, and will ever take more and more from you!

Possibly a lord will provide vein here. The idea that what one ought to have is what one does have. A passive acceptance of what arrives. The townsfolk think it is being stoic but it is really just another form of submission. Zarathustra warns what comes from this line of thinking. All the things in life that befall you good or bad will sap your strength. The townsfolk are not open to the universe, they are dissolving into the universe. Next line,

[3_49:63] Ah, that ye would renounce all HALF-willing, and would decide for idleness as ye decide for action!

Zarathustra does not see virtues as the mean between vices like Aristotle. He sees them as the tension between. This line would suggest that instead of staggering along between the poles of action and idleness it would be better to just fully will it.

He attacks the half-willing, the lukewarm townsfolk who compromise. If you are not going to act then it would be better to fully own your idleness, then live with the consequences. They have already chosen comfort, they just will not admit it. Next line,

[3_49:64] Ah, that ye understood my word: “Do ever what ye will—but first be such as CAN WILL.

He could be turning to us the reader of the book now as well as wishing that anyone in the town would understand his demand. A demand that we first develop the ability to will. With him not even caring what it is we will, only that we decide and strive towards it. Next line,

[3_49:65] Love ever your neighbour as yourselves—but first be such as LOVE THEMSELVES—

A reference to [1_16:1] “Ye crowd around your neighbour, and have fine words for it. But I say unto you: your neighbor-love is your bad love of yourselves.”

He is using the Christian ideal of loving your neighbour as one loves oneself but reverses the morality of it. Love of your neighbour requires self-love. Otherwise it is fawning, pity, manipulation, and control. Next line,

[3_49:66] —Such as love with great love, such as love with great contempt!” Thus speaketh Zarathustra the godless.—

Now this is the ethic of Zarathustra love, the twin engines of love as embracing and love as discipline. We have heard of god’s love for man, this is Zarathustra’s love of man and it is godless. Next line,

[3_49:67] But why talk I, when no one hath MINE ears! It is still an hour too early for me here.

Could be following the theme of the Joyful Science 125 where a man rejected by the crowd announces that he is premature.¹⁷ In any case Zarathustra recaps his assessment that the townsfolk do not have the ears for him. Yet we get an indication that something will happen that will reverse the bedwarfing virtue. Next line,

[3_49:68] Mine own forerunner am I among this people, mine own cockcrow in dark lanes.

Amongst the townsfolk they are so degraded and he is so early it becomes comical. He is not the herald of the *Übermensch* in book 1, he is the herald of the herald. A rooster should crow at dawn yet is now crowing in the dark, thus he is amongst these townsfolk. Next line,

[3_49:69] But THEIR hour cometh! And there cometh also mine! Hourly do they become smaller, poorer, unfruitfuller,—poor herbs! poor earth!

The townsfolk and Zarathustra's countdown run in tandem. Even by the hour the bedwarfing virtue acts on them. The image of herbs and earth are one of depletion, that is losing the ability to support any fruit. Next line,

[3_49:70] And SOON shall they stand before me like dry grass and prairie, and verily, weary of themselves—and panting for FIRE, more than for water!

Zarathustra being a bit of a megalomaniac here. Eventually the townsfolk undifferentiated, reduced from beings with agency to combustible matter swaying with every breeze. In that state they will become bored of what they are wishing to not live like this but to go out in a blaze. The comfort driven life demanded a nihilistic destructive escape to feel anything at all. Next line,

¹⁷Nietzsche, Friedrich Wilhelm. n.d. "The Joyful Wisdom ('La Gaya Scienza') Complete Works, Volume Ten."

<https://www.gutenberg.org/Files/52124/52124-h/52124-H.htm>.

<https://www.gutenberg.org/cache/epub/52124/pg52124-images.html>.

[3_49:71] O blessed hour of the lightning! O mystery before noontide!—Running fires will I one day make of them, and heralds with flaming tongues:—

Blessed hour of the lighting. The sudden eruption of energy. The opposite of steady ticktock time. The mystery before the noontide, the moment right before the sun is at the highest point and shadows vanish. At that moment he will turn them into ifuel for such a fire. Next line,

[3_49:72] —Herald shall they one day with flaming tongues: It cometh, it is nigh, THE GREAT NOONTIDE!

Thus the arc is complete. The townsfolk who did not have time for him, who rejected him, who shrank and shrank and shrank will one day desire his fire. He will oblige and they shall become his heralds. The heralds who proclaim the kingdom of god, but instead the great noontide of the godless. Next line,

[3_49:73] Thus spake Zarathustra.

Traditional ending of the section.

Notes:

[3_49:24-32] Seeking comfort as the primary leads to moderate tame virtue. Leading to hobbled slowed progress. Creating awful actors who slip in and out of roles. Weakening the naturally strong such that the naturally weak must step up. All leading to the hypocrisy of rulers who pretend to not rule.

The expressionist school understands this section to be presented as contrasting the self-serving love vs self-preserving love¹⁸

Rehder, Helmut. "Nietzsche and His Place in German Literature 1844-1944." *Monatshefte Für Deutschen Unterricht* 36, no. 8 (1944): 425–45. <http://www.jstor.org/stable/30170105>.

¹⁸Rehder, Helmut. "Nietzsche and His Place in German Literature 1844-1944." *Monatshefte Für Deutschen Unterricht* 36, no. 8 (1944): 425–45. <http://www.jstor.org/stable/30170105>.

<https://mythopedia.com/topics/oceanus/>

Beyond Oceanus lies the entrance to the Underworld,^[11] the Isles of the Blessed

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